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Hosea

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Hosea

A. Overview and Summary.

1. The book of Hosea was written by the prophet Hosea, as recorded in verse 1:1. This book begins a series of what are called the 12 minor prophets in the Old Testament. The term “minor” refers to their length, not that they are insignificant. Hosea prophesied for about 60 years; it is believed that the book Hosea was written between 755 and 725 BC. Hosea means “salvation”, “He saves”, or “He helps”. Although not specifically identified as such, due to the detail and familiarity of the Northern Kingdom, it is believed that he was physically located in the Northern Kingdom of Israel. His message is mostly given to the Northern Kingdom of Israel although it also addresses Judah, the Southern Kingdom. Israel is frequently called Ephraim in this book, after the largest tribe in the Northern Kingdom.
2. A prophet is one who conveys a message of God to people. In one sense, they are the bridge between heaven and earth. Many times, prophets proclaim what God has spoken to them and relate it to the people. They are proclaiming what God has spoken about various issues of the day to correct or adjust behavior. Other times, prophets are foretelling future events, either in close proximity to the time of the prophet, or looking far ahead into the future. Still other times, what prophets do is demonstration, or acting out a role which God has assigned in order to gain attention of the people to convey His message. We see all three methods at play in this book.
3. Hosea is given a very difficult assignment by God. He is told to: “Go, take to yourself a wife of whoredom and children of whoredom; for the land commits great whoredom, departing from Jehovah” (Vs. 1:2b). Hosea is to demonstrate the analogy of Israel being like an adulterous wife by committing idolatry and forsaking her marriage relationship to God. But the analogy also includes Hosea redeeming his adulterous wife as God will also redeem adulterous Israel at the end of days. This demonstrates His faithful commitment to His covenants, and His steadfast love, typified by Hosea’s long suffering as a husband of an unfaithful wife.
4. Hosea can be divided into two parts. The first part, chapter 1 verse one through chapter 3 verse 5, symbolizes Israel, the unfaithful wife to God through idolatry. The second part, chapter 4 verse 1 through chapter 14 verse 9, contains the

condemnation of Israel and her eventual restoration. Key chapters and verses will be summarized.

B. Chapter 1.

1. Hosea takes Gomer as his wife and she conceives and bears him a son that God tells him to name "Jezreel". Jezreel is the name of a valley in Israel which means "God scatters". This is likened to sowing seed by scattering them. In the Hebrew, Jezreel and Israel are almost identical in spelling and in pronunciation. This is a play on words that we don't get in translations. God is pronouncing a judgement on Israel, that He will scatter the ten northern tribes to the nations. This occurred in 722 BC by means of the Assyrian conquest, due to Israel's unfaithfulness to Him. The Assyrian strategy was to take people of countries they conquered and scatter them into other countries that they had conquered, and bring those people back into the one they just conquered. This resulted in a mingling of the people, a breaking down of ethnic strongholds and a weakening of nationalistic ties. This happened to Israel, and that is how the Samaritans came about. This is why the Jews of the Southern Kingdom would later have such a dislike of the Samaritans.
2. Gomer conceives again and brings forth a daughter. God tells Hosea to name her Loruhamah which means "no mercy". God further tells Hosea: "for I will no longer have mercy on the house of Israel, to forgive them at all. But I will have mercy on the house of Judah, and I will save them by the LORD their God. I will not save them by bow or by sword or by war or by horses or by horsemen" (Vs. 1:6b-7). God was telling Hosea that Israel could no longer expect mercy from Him but, Judah would continue, and He would rescue them from the Assyrians, but not due to their own military strength. This prophecy was fulfilled when the Assyrian army under king Sennacherib surrounded Jerusalem as described in Isaiah chapter 37. Judah's king Hezekiah prayed and an angel from God destroyed 185,000 Assyrian soldiers in one night. Sennacherib returns to his capital where he is assassinated by his sons. Archeological excavations of cities in the areas conquered by the Assyrians all have what is called the Assyrian destruction layer, except for Jerusalem. Jerusalem was spared for another 136 years but was conquered by the Babylonians in 586 BC. The Jews were exiled for 70 years in Babylon until a remnant would return, as detailed in Ezra and Nehemiah.
3. Gomer conceives again and the son is named "Lo-ammi" which means "not my people": "for you are not my people, and I am not your God (Vs. 1:9b)." But then

God gives a prophecy of future restoration: "Yet the number of the children of Israel shall be like the sand of the sea, which cannot be measured or numbered. And in the place where it was said to them, "'You are not my people, '"it shall be said to them, "'Children of the living God.'" And the children of Judah and the children of Israel shall be gathered together, and they shall appoint for themselves one head. And they shall go up from the land, for great shall be the day of Jezreel" (Vs.1:10-11).

C. Chapter 2. The chapter continues to describe Gomer's unfaithfulness as an analogy of Israel's unfaithfulness to the Lord. But the chapter ends with a promise of restoration: "And I will have mercy on No Mercy, and I will say to Not My People, 'You are my people'; and he shall say, 'You are my God (Vs.2:23b).'"

D. Chapter 3. The Lord tells Hosea to "Go again, love a woman who is loved by another man and is an adulteress, even as the LORD loves the children of Israel, though they turn to other gods" (Vs.3:1). Hosea buys her for 15 shekels of silver and a measure of barley.

E. Chapter 4. This is the beginning of the second part of Hosea. The chapter opens with: "Hear the word of the LORD, O children of Israel, for the LORD has a controversy with the inhabitants of the land. There is no faithfulness or steadfast love, and no knowledge of God in the land; there is swearing, lying, murder, stealing, and committing adultery; they break all bounds, and bloodshed follows bloodshed." (Vs. 4:1-2). Knowledge of the Lord and his Word is crucial to avoiding sin.

F. Chapter 5 is a continuation of condemnation of both Israel and Judah.

G. Chapter 6. The first two verses of this chapter are seen by some to be a prophecy of the Lord's return: "Come, let us return to the LORD; for He has torn us, that He may heal us; He has struck us down, and He will bind us up. After two days He will revive us; on the third day He will raise us up, that we may live before Him" (Vs. 6:1-2). Coupled with Psalm 90:4 and 2 Peter 3:8, that indicate that 1,000 years is like a day unto the Lord, the interpretation is that it has been almost 2,000 years, or two days, since the Jews rejected Christ as their Messiah, in about 33 AD. They have been "bound up", but "after two days" would mean that it is close to the time when He would "raise them up" for the third day of the 1,000-year Millennium Kingdom. Israel will be "raised up" and accept Christ as Messiah when He returns. Only time will tell if this is truly an end times prophecy.

H. Chapters 7 through 14. These chapters are a continuation of lamentation over Israel's unfaithfulness as well as some over Judah. The book closes with a plea to return to the Lord and a word about wisdom: "Whoever is wise, let him understand these things; whoever is discerning, let him know them; for the ways of the LORD are right, and the upright walk in them, but transgressors stumble in them" (Vs. 14:9).

I. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. Hosea is a picture of a loving God who agonizes over his unfaithful wife, Israel. Yet, He promises to restore her. We are currently in the time of the Gentiles, or the church age. Israel, and later Judah experienced God's wrath, due to their idolatry, when first the Assyrians and then the Babylonians conquered Israel and then Judah. After the Babylonian captivity, Israel never again has a history of idolatry. Have you ever experienced the Lord's restoration after a time of not walking with Him? What does Hosea tell you about the unfailing love of God for His people?
2. We cannot know the day or the hour of the Lord's return, but we are to be watchful and stay "awake" (Mark 13:32-37). How might Hosea 6:1-2 be something that would encourage us to do so?

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